

Carving a career

At the outbreak of World War II, Nixon secured a job at the federal government rations office in Washington, D.C., where he got his first taste of Washington politics. He was, however, unhappy sitting behind a desk when a war was taking place, so he enlisted in the US Navy. Posted to the Solomon Islands in the Pacific, he helped coordinate cargo operations. After the war, he remained a member of the Navy Reserves until 1966.

Southern California Republicans searching for a rising star convinced Nixon to run for US Congress in 1946. Victory led him back to Washington and a meteoric political career that took him to the Senate in 1950 and then the White House in 1953, when he became Dwight Eisenhower's vice president. Nixon was known as a zealous anticommunist and a politician willing to cut ethical corners in order to win office—a reputation that earned him the nickname Tricky Dick.

TV politician

Nixon was one of the first politicians to exploit the power of television—he earned fame for his 1952 “Checkers” speech rebutting allegations of financial irregularities while campaigning as Eisenhower's running mate. However, his tired appearance in a televised presidential debate with John F. Kennedy in 1960 (Nixon was recovering from flu) probably cost him the White House. He was defeated again in 1962, running for governor of California, but won the presidential election in 1968 with his promise to bring the troops home from Vietnam.

Nixon did bring the troops home. His Vietnamization program, ping-pong diplomacy, and détente with China, including his landmark visit to Beijing in 1972, culminated in the Paris Peace Accords of 1973.

Despite his conservative leanings, Nixon's environmental policies were often progressive. He created the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) and supported the Clean Air Act of 1970. The Nixon White House also launched the controversial War on Drugs, which some thought was a way to attack two of the constituencies that most opposed him—Black Americans and young, liberal whites.

Watergate and after

Despite running well ahead of Democrat George McGovern in the 1972 presidential election, Nixon could not divorce himself from the dirty tricks that had always marked his campaigns. On June 17, 1972, five men were arrested for breaking into the Democratic party headquarters at the Watergate complex. *Washington Post* reporters Bob Woodward and Carl Bernstein linked the burglars to the White House. The scandal forced Nixon to resign in August 1974.

President Gerald Ford, Nixon's successor, granted him a full pardon in September 1974. Nixon began the process of rehabilitating his image by writing books and making high-profile foreign trips. He spent his last 15 years living in and around New York City, finally passing away at his home in New Jersey in April 1994.